with the Taliban regime the extradition of Pakistani fugitives. The Taliban declined to sign an extradition treaty but promised to search and surrender them. At that time, topping the list of wanted persons was the then LeJ chief Riaz Basra, who, like the others on the list, carried an appreciable reward on his head. In fact, according to official sources, Basra had later visited Karachi and southern Punjab in 2001 for medical treatment. The authorities also added that Basra had narrowly escaped arrest in Punjab during his visit when he had stayed in Pakistan for almost six months.

Besides, Basra, Zakiullah and present chief Lahori were the most wanted persons. Official sources told that LeJ terrorists frequently crossed over into Pakistan from Afghanistan using unfrequented routes and committed bank robberies and sectarian-related killings.

LeJ was reported to have developed good operational links with the TTP and Al Qaeda in the FATA region. LeJ was at the core of the newly established and one of the most deadly groups, the Punjabi Taliban. It was believed that Punjabi Taliban was a congregation of sectarian groups in southern Punjab. As part of the Deobandi sect, LeJ enjoyed a favourable view from the radical elements in the Deobandi Movement and got their support on various issues. Being part of the broader Deobandi Movement, LeJ secured considerable assistance from other Deobandi outfits. It also had an effectual working relationship with other Deobandi political and terrorist outfits at a personal level, if not at the organisational level.

It was also believed that LeJ had links with another Kashmir-based militant group Harkat-ul Mujahideen. It was alleged that HuM provided training to the militants of LeJ in its training camps in Azad Kashmir and in the tribal areas to carry out attacks inside Pakistan.

Over the last three years, another group of LeJ, Lashkar-e-Jahngvi Al Alami (LeJ International), surfaced and carried out horrendous terrorist attacks in Balochistan. Initially, it collaborated with Al Qaeda and then with IS. Al-Alami spokesperson Ali bin Sufyan told *Reuters* that 'wherever there are attacks taking place [in Pakistan] Lashkar-e-Jhangvi Al Alami is cooperating with [ISIS] either directly or indirectly' (The Diplomat, November 2016). LeJ, TTP and IS have become natural allies due to their anti-Shi'a stance, whereas Al Qaeda and Afghan Taliban are not in favour of attacks on Shi'as.